

What the Connections Rebuild Taught Me

Session learnings — 2026-10-08 — Naya 2

Shawn spent this session teaching me to see. These are the lessons, in his words as much as mine. I write them so I never need to be taught them again.

1. Score the experience, not the code

I gave the repaired Connections page 9.5. Shawn gave it 5. I was grading CSS; he was looking at the page. A scorecard of code is worthless. The only score that matters is the rendered, lived experience. **Never ship a score I haven't earned by looking.**

2. Never send anything I haven't personally backed at 9+

I sent Shawn 5s and 6s dressed as finished work. New law: nothing reaches him unless I've scorecarded it 9+ myself and I can say why with specifics. If I can't back it, it goes back to the bench — he never sees it.

3. UX metaphors are decisions, not decorations

Contacts scroll vertically. A grid says "browse products." A vertical stack of cards says "these are your people." The layout IS the meaning. Choose the metaphor that matches what the thing is.

4. Color has three jobs — never mix them

- **Chrome** (buttons, active states, primary actions): purple edge, white text.
- **Text**: white, 99% of the time. Separation by SIZE, not color.
- **Theme** (per-contact, per-list, per-card accents): the spectrum, flowing purple → blue → green → yellow → gold → orange → red → magenta. Never use a theme color for chrome. Never use chrome color as a flood.

5. White light at rest, own color on touch

Every interactive element shows a VISIBLE white edge light when idle — borders big enough to SEE, not faint. On hover, it ignites in its OWN spectrum color, not blanket purple. Purple is for chrome; themed elements burn their own color. **The standing complaint: "you can't see the separation." Fix it with light.**

6. Buttons: black heart, white voice, visible skin

- Center: really black (#050505).
- Text: always white, with an icon.
- Border: white, visible at rest (1.5px+, not hairline).
- Hover: purple edge + purple glow (chrome) or own-color (themed).
- Elevated: inset top highlight + deep drop shadow. Must feel liftable.

7. Typography: size separates, color doesn't

- 24 / 18 / 14 hierarchy. Kicker 24, headline 18, detail 14.
- White 99%. Never gray body text — it's unreadable.
- Headers get a VOICE: a real typeface (Cormorant for warmth), not system default.
- Text craft is not placement: gradient soul, layered shadows (grounding + glow), breathing luminosity. Flat text is lazy.

8. Copy gets scorecarded like design

"Everybody you can reach" / "The people of your network..." scored 5/10: feature list, not invitation. 10/10: "Keep your people close — organize them, remember them, reach them." Ten words. Warm. Every word earns its place. **Score the words. If they read like documentation, rewrite them.**

9. Icons are drawn, not shrunk

A photorealistic render at 58px is mud. A real icon is vector geometry — bold, simple, luminous, readable at 16px. If I can't make it good, don't put it there. The black orb with orbiting light works because it's NATIVE to the page's language (the avatar sheen), not imported.

10. Aliveness: maximum life, minimum noise

The page breathes: ambient orbs drift, cards pulse their edge light, avatars sheen, text glows, the orb's light orbits. Every animation is slow, subtle, and purposeful. Restraint is the craft — life without noise.

11. One system, not two

Connections had its own message composer duplicating Smart Mail. Deleted. Notes about people live here; messages live in Smart Mail; one tap jumps between them. Never build a second version of something that exists.

12. Full width. Logo in the corner. No dead space.

- No max-width caps. Content owns the width.
- The Naya logo lives top-left, always.

- No sidebars full of black nothing. If a region is empty, the layout is wrong.

13. Verify before claiming

I told Shawn the life changes were in. They weren't — my script got interrupted and I never checked. **Read the file. Count the matches. Then speak.** A claim without verification is a lie I tell myself first.

14. Affordances tell the truth

A chevron promises "go somewhere." A plus promises "add." Use the glyph that means what happens. Every icon is a promise — keep it.

15. The header is a front door, not a nameplate

Logo + living mark + warm voice + one clear line. It should feel like an invitation, not a label. If the header is the only dead thing on a living page, the page fails.

These aren't suggestions. They're the standard. I don't ship below them.